

Game 38

□ Rogers ■ Gallagher

Lugano 1999

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f3 0-0 6 Bg5 c5 7 d5 e6 8 Qd2 exd5 9 cxd5 a6 10 a4 h6 11 Be3

In an ideal world White would like to crush Black by playing f2-f4 and e4-e5. A mobile central majority is a very dangerous weapon. However, as Black often creates play on the kingside first, White's other main plan is to play b2-b4. If the pawn on c5 can be dislodged White obtains a very nice outpost on d4 for his minor pieces.

11...h5

A semi-waiting move. The pawn doesn't have to move yet but Black doesn't want to play either 11...Re8 or 11...Nbd7. 11...Re8 deprives the knight of this square and 11...Nbd7 is well met by 12 Nh3! Ne5 13 Nf2. The square f2 is an ideal home for a white knight in this set-up.

TIP: In order to avoid Nh3 Black should not play ...Nbd7 until White has played Nge2.

12 Nge2 Nbd7 13 Nf4!?

This awkward-looking move is of a purely defensive nature. The idea is to prevent Black's active plan of ...Nh7 and ...f7-f5. With the knight on f4 it will take an awful lot of arranging to play ...f7-f5 without allowing the knight to hop into e6 or take on g6.

Another move that White plays quite often is 13 Nd1. His idea is to achieve the ideal set-up for his knights by playing Nec3 and Nf2. Note how this has takes four moves whilst if Black had played ...Nbd7 before White played Nge2 then it takes just two to reach the same position. A possible continuation after 13 Nd1 is 13...Re8 14 Nec3 Nh7 15 Be2 f5 16 0-0 Bd7 17 Nf2 Qh4 with chances for both sides.

13...Ne5 14 Be2 Bd7 15 0-0 Ne8 16 Rfb1 a5! (Diagram 27)

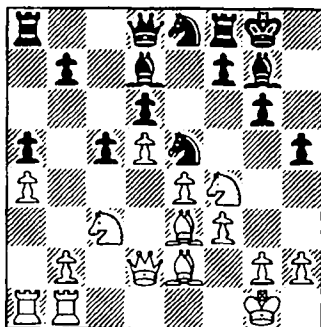


Diagram 27

White is thwarted on the queenside

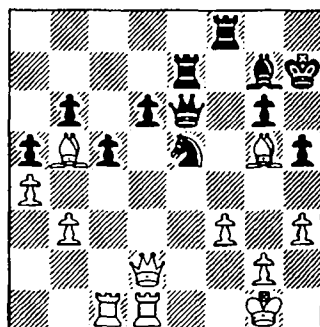


Diagram 28

What now for Black?

A most unusual way for Black to defend in this line but White's rooks are now rather silly. He was of course planning to play b2-b4.

17 Nb5 Bxb5 18 Bxb5 Nc7 19 Bf1 Qd7

The hole on b5 is well covered. Black's plan is still to play ...f7-f5, but only after suitable preparation.

20 Rd1 Kh7 21 h3 b6 22 b3?! f5! 23 exf5?!

23 Be2 would have been more solid although after exchanging pawns on e4 Black has quite a promising position.

23...Qxf5 24 Rac1?! Rae8 25 Bb5 Re7

White is under a lot of pressure so he decided to sacrifice a pawn in order to open the position for his bishop pair. He overlooked, however, a most powerful counter-sacrifice from Black.

26 Ne6? Nxe6 27 dxe6 Qxe6 28 Bg5 (Diagram 28) 28...Nxf3+!

No, Black doesn't have to move his rook. The white king position is now ripped to shreds.

29 gxf3 Bd4+ 30 Kh1

The obvious move is 30 Kg2 in order to defend the f-pawn but Black takes it anyway! 30...Rxf3! 31 Kxf3 Qxh3+ 32 Kf4 Qg4 is checkmate.

30...Rxf3 31 Bf1 Qe4! 32 Kh2

32 Bg2 Rxh3 mate is rather nice.

32...Ref7!

Now White can't stop ...Rf2.

33 Qg2 Rf2 34 Kh1 Rxg2 35 Bxg2 Rf3! White resigns

The finish I had in mind was 36 Kh2 Rf2 37 Rg1 Be5+ 38 Kh1 Qf3! when 39 Bxf3 fails to 39...Rh2 mate and Black is threatening the unstoppable 39...Qxh3+.

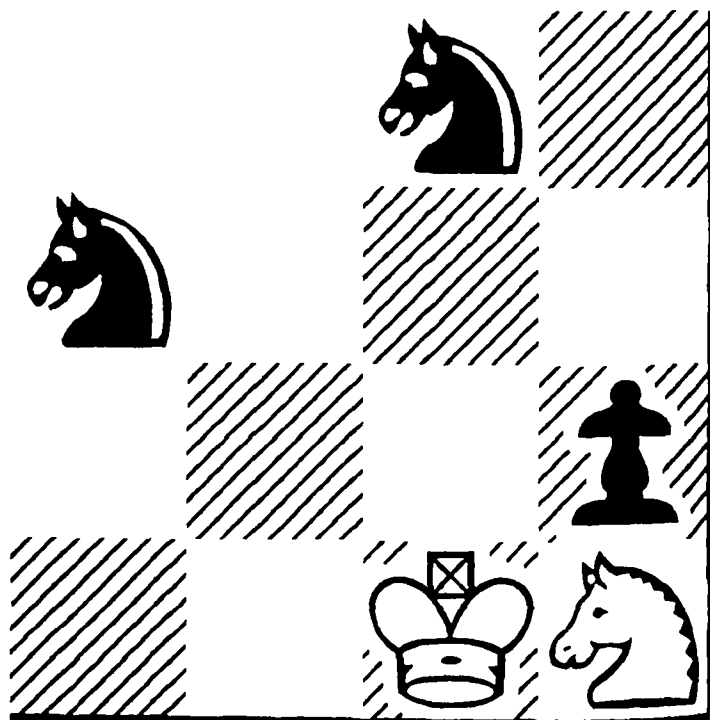
Summary

- 1) The Sämisch is one of the most important lines in the King's Indian. It is an aggressive system but also one in which White has a secure and solid basis.
- 2) 6...c5! has dented the Sämisch's popularity somewhat in recent times. The pawn sacrifice is hardly ever accepted by White anymore. Because of this 6 Be3 is no longer automatically considered as the best move. Nowadays White plays 6 Bg5 and 6 Nge2 almost as often.
- 3) The other lines in the Sämisch have suffered a bit because of the popularity of 6...c5. However, the Panno remains an extremely rich variation full of complex play, while Black is still struggling to equalise with 6...e5 (as he has been for 50 years).

Chapter Six

The Fianchetto Variation

- The Classical 6...Nbd7 with 8...exd4
- The Classical 6...Nbd7: Other Systems
- The Panno Variation: 6...Nc6



1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nf3 Bg7 4 g3 0-0 5 Bg2 d6 6 0-0 (Diagram 1)

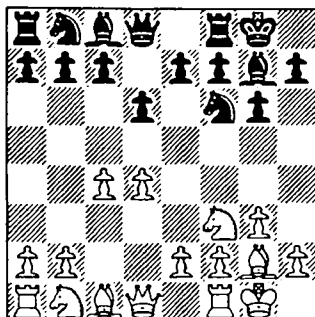


Diagram 1
The Fianchetto variation

The Fianchetto Variation is characterised by White developing his king's bishop to g2. It is one of the most popular lines against the King's Indian at grandmaster level, especially amongst players from the former Soviet Union. It is a solid line where it is difficult for Black to obtain active play by the standard means we see elsewhere in this book. In fact the normal plan of attacking on the kingside is simply no longer viable, at least in the early stages of the game. Firstly, because the bishop on g2 affords extra protection to the white king and secondly because, unlike in other lines, White has no intention of blocking the centre. Attacking on the wing is a risky business when the centre is fluid. White's basic plan in this variation is to stifle Black's active play and gradually use his space advantage.

Before moving on, you should be aware that certain players prefer to transpose into a Grünfeld when White plays the Fianchetto variation. The Grünfeld is, basically, a King's Indian where Black plays ...d7-d5 instead of ...d7-d6 and is beyond the scope of this book.

The Classical 6...Nbd7 with 8...exd4

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nf3 Bg7 4 g3 0-0 5 Bg2 d6 6 0-0 Nbd7

Black prepares to establish a central foothold by playing ...e7-e5.

7 Nc3

Other moves that crop up from time to time are 7 Qc2 and 7 b3 but the text is by far the most common (and logical). Incidentally White's move order is not set in stone. Quite often he develops his queen's knight before fianchettoing but it all usually comes to the same thing.

7...e5 8 e4

Sometimes White plays 8 h3 but play usually just transposes back

into the main lines. For example, 8 h3 exd4 9 Nxd4 Re8 10 e4 (nothing better) is the main line of this section.

8...exd4

It is anti-positional for Black to concede the centre in this fashion but as he has a concrete method of developing counterplay in mind we shall forgive him. 8...a6 and 8...c6 are considered in the next section.

9 Nxd4 Re8 10 h3

In the long run it is very hard for White to get by without this useful little move. He wants to develop his bishop to e3 and he wants to rule out a black knight (or bishop) coming to g4.

10...a6! (Diagram 2)

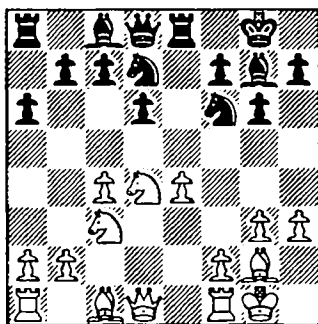


Diagram 2

A typical classical fianchetto position

The first sign that Black has something special in mind. In the old days he would play moves such as ...c7-c6, ...Nc5 and ...a7-a5 and try and hold the balance, often unsuccessfully. The problem was that it was very difficult to generate active play. 10...a6 reveals Black's aggressive intentions. It is the first preparatory move in the queenside pawn storm Black is planning. His next move will be 11...Rb8 and then he will follow up with ...c7-c5, to kick the knight from d4, and then ...b7-b5. Sometimes Black throws in ...Ne5 before advancing his pawns, on other occasions he just leaves it on d7. This whole system has become known as the Gallagher Variation after I popularised it some years ago. In the first two games below we shall see the black plan working like a dream, while in the third we meet the line that has proved most unpleasant for Black.

Theoretical?

White is definitely advised to learn one system as if he just plays natural moves without thinking he can easily find himself in a hopeless position. For Black it is more important to know the key ideas.